

CRANES, RAILS, AND RELATIVES

From graceful dancing cranes to small skulking rails, this order contains a wide variety of ground-dwelling birds of both dry and wetland habitats.

Mostly long-legged and long-billed, birds in the order Gruiformes are behaviourally very diverse. Cranes walk on the ground, do not perch on trees,

and have short toes with the hind toe reduced or absent. The finfoots and coots have lobed, not webbed, feet. Rails and crakes have longer toes and a body that is deep but very slim, helping movement through dense vegetation, including reedbeds, in marshes or drier areas. Some on remote islands are flightless.

PHYLUM	CHORDATA
CLASS	AVES
ORDER	GRUIFORMES
FAMILIES	6
SPECIES	188



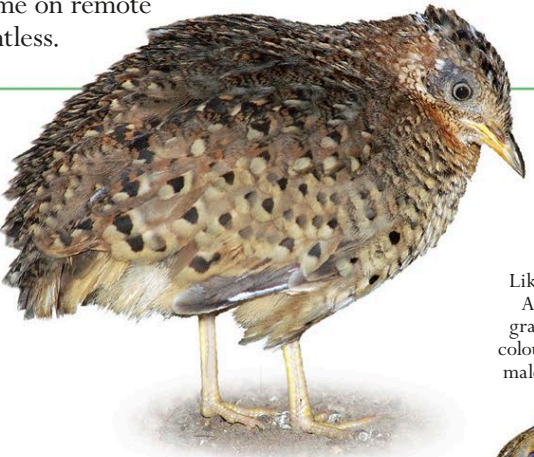
65–70 cm
26–28 in

olive-brown wings and body

long, grey legs

LIMPKIN
Aramus guarauna
F: Aramidae

Mostly nocturnal, this small cousin of cranes inhabits tropical American wetlands and uses its tweezer-like bill to extract snails from shells.



15 cm
6 in

YELLOW-LEGGED BUTTONQUAIL
Turnix tanki
F: Turnicidae

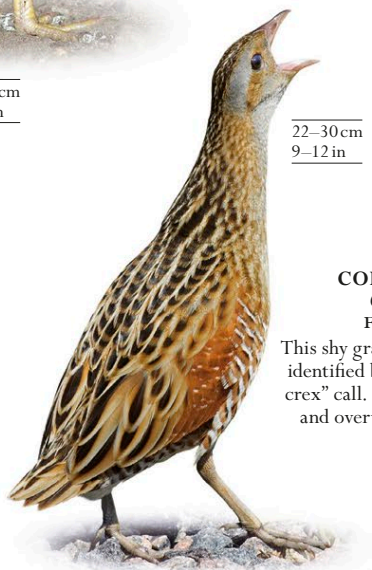
Like other buttonquails, this east Asian species inhabits tropical grasslands. The females are more colourful, and compete for the drab males, who take care of the young.



19–23 cm
7½–9 in

BLACK CRAKE
Amaurornis flavirostra
F: Rallidae

This African crake is widespread south of the Sahara. Unlike many of its secretive relatives, it is often seen out in the open.



22–30 cm
9–12 in

CORNCRAKE
Crex crex
F: Rallidae

This shy grassland crake is best identified by its rasping “crex crex” call. It breeds in Eurasia and overwinters in Africa.



28–33 cm
11–13 in

BUFF-BANDED RAIL
Gallirallus philippensis
F: Rallidae

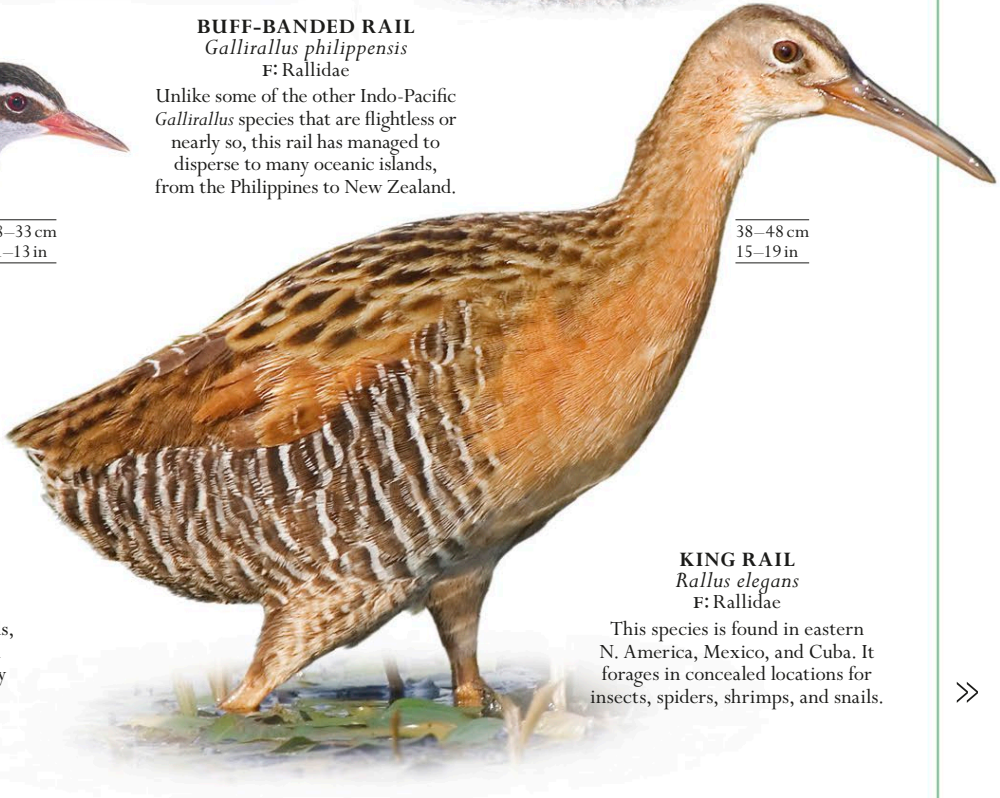
Unlike some of the other Indo-Pacific *Gallirallus* species that are flightless or nearly so, this rail has managed to disperse to many oceanic islands, from the Philippines to New Zealand.



13–18 cm
5–7 in

YELLOW RAIL
Coturnicops noveboracensis
F: Rallidae

One of several barred-backed rails, this tiny, secretive N. American species is most easily detected by its nocturnal clicking call.



38–48 cm
15–19 in

KING RAIL
Rallus elegans
F: Rallidae

This species is found in eastern N. America, Mexico, and Cuba. It forages in concealed locations for insects, spiders, shrimps, and snails.